



FLORIDA DEPARTMENT OF Environmental Protection

Marjory Stoneman Douglas Building
3900 Commonwealth Boulevard
Tallahassee, FL 32399

Ron DeSantis
Governor

Jeanette Nuñez
Lt. Governor

Shawn Hamilton
Secretary

September 30, 2024

Reconnecting Communities Program Team:

I am writing to express my strong support for the Bluffline project's application for the U.S. Department of Transportation's Reconnecting Communities grant. As the Greenways and Trails Coordinator for the North Region of the Florida Department of Environmental Protection (FDEP), I am dedicated to advancing projects that enhance connectivity and environmental sustainability through regional trail networks. The Bluffline is an exemplary initiative that aligns with both state and regional priorities, playing a crucial role in transforming Pensacola and Escambia County's greenway system.

This corridor has been identified as a priority corridor within the Florida Greenways and Trails System. It has also been identified as a Priority 1 trail corridor within the *Florida-Alabama Regional Bicycle & Pedestrian Master Plan*. These designations highlight the importance of the Bluffline corridor for achieving long-distance, multi-county connectivity. Development of this corridor would also enhance recreational access and alternative transportation routes, which are critical for both environmental protection and the well-being of local communities.

This visionary project would reconnect residents with Pensacola's waterfront, provide safe pedestrian and cycling pathways, and foster economic development by promoting tourism and recreation. As part of a statewide effort to expand trail networks and create more resilient communities, the Bluffline exemplifies the type of forward-thinking, community-centered infrastructure that the Reconnecting Communities grant seeks to support.

If you have any questions regarding this letter, please contact Justin Baldwin via email, Justin.Baldwin@FloridaDEP.gov.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink that reads "Justin Baldwin". The signature is written in a cursive, flowing style.

Justin Baldwin
Regional Coordinator
Division of Recreation and Parks
Office of Greenways and Trails